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Niger Ibos

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CHAPTER XIII YOUTH TO OLD AGE — BOYS & MEN

A boy lives in his mother's hut until he is old enough to build quarters for himself. Then he builds a small hut where he sleeps, stores his treasures, and receives his friends. When he is ready to marry, the general procedure is to inaugurate a new compound. Once that is established, beyond occasional repairs and the annual fieldwork, he has little cause to exert himself. When he does additional work, it is mainly in order to raise initiation fees for a title. To enhance his social status, he endeavours to add to the number of his wives, and to advance to higher grades of titular honours. He cannot do either, without finding ways to make money: for these purposes he must work.

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On reaching manhood's estate, every free-born youth automatically enters upon the privileges and duties of citizenship, and bears his share in all that appertains to the well-being of the village. He is called upon to contribute to the public festivals and sacrificial obligations, and to pay his quota towards any expenses incurred by the town. As required, he must render personal service in war and peace; also he must give support to the head of his house, and to the king or paramount chief where there is one. The demand may be for money to assist the chief in his desire to take up a higher title, or a contribution towards the expenses of building a more dignified dwelling, or to give his services in fieldwork. Custom rules that every fourth day should be at the disposal of the head of the family or clan.

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Men who are traders, or who practise a specific craft, spend several months of each year in the districts where they find it profitable to operate. They return home, some for three or four months, others for a shorter period. Of late years, it has become a custom to spend the Christmas and New Year season at their homes. The holiday is devoted very largely to feasting and entertaining. Palm wine and, nowadays, foreign liquors are much more in evidence than at other seasons of the year.

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The old folk continue to favour the product of the country, the superior young men like to flaunt their supplies of bottled beer and spirits. The men have extraordinary capacities, and  197 seem able to drink unthinkable quantities and yet, in the Ibo country, drunkenness is seldom a public spectacle. One of the most noticeable features is the serious manner in which drinking is conducted, particularly in the early stages. The arrangements appear to be governed by a determined purpose to drain all the vessels at a steady rate of round upon round until all the liquor is consumed. The men squat about with the pots and demijohns in the centre. There is little conversation: no more than an occasional remark or passing joke, nor are there any signs of revelry at this earlier stage: all are intent on the one purpose of drinking. No man willingly leaves the party until the wine-pots are empty: it is considered bad form, or folly, to forfeit one's chance to share the drink. One of the younger men has charge of the supply, and he fills and refills the horn or calabash of each man in order of seniority.⁴ It can scarcely be termed "drinking". There is no tasting, no smacking of the lips in appreciation of the flavour; the liquor flows in an unbroken stream as easily as water down a drain-pipe. This is the practice with freshly drawn palm wine. As fermentation increases (by the simple process of allowing the wine to stand), it becomes too much like vinegar to be palatable. Though it is seldom declined, it is not popular as a drink, and only moderate quantities of strongly fermented wine are consumed. It must be repeated that, in spite of what is stated here, the Ibos, on the whole, can genuinely be described as sober people. (*Vide* p. 125.)

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⁴ At Onitsha the one drinking vessel passes round the assembly. In the interior each man carries his own calabash. He never trusts it in the hands of another, ever having in mind the fear of poison.

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